

Associate Candidate Assignment

Prompt

District X context

District X is a large, public school district in the United States serving roughly 61,000 students from under-resourced communities.

District leaders are aware that they have not met the learning needs of students with disabilities. They also know they haven't met the learning needs of students from low-income families, who are learning English, or who identify as Black or Latinx students. This has occurred for several years.

More specifically, on average...

- Students from low-income families who speak English as a second language score lower on state tests than their peers of a higher socioeconomic status who are native English speakers.
- Black and Latinx students have scored lower than their white peers.

Many of District X's neighboring cities see similar gaps in performance, but the difference is larger in District X than in surrounding cities.

Meanwhile, District X's budget has become increasingly tight as student enrollment has declined in recent years. The superintendent suspects that their school funding system no longer provides schools the resources they need to serve increasing student needs. This is especially true considering recent budget cuts.

District X's strategic plan states that the district's goal is to: meet each student's distinct needs by finding the right combination of resources that create high-quality learning experiences so that every student can reach high standards and thrive.

When your project team talked to the superintendent about that goal, she said, "Our District X motto is *excellence through equity*. To us, equity means that students who face additional challenges because of their background, family income, home language, or learning needs should have the additional resources they need to succeed. Equity also means that Black and Latinx students should also receive the resources they need to excel."

District leaders agree that equitable school experiences require more than just school funding. They suggested teacher expertise, learning time, and supportive school culture as some of the other resources students need. However, leaders in District X are unsure how to assess their progress in meeting the goals outlined in their strategic plan.

Superintendent's key questions

District X has signed a contract with our organization to investigate the four questions below from the superintendent. **Your presentation needs these questions clearly and directly.**

1. Is funding in District X distributed equitably across schools according to their students' needs?
2. If not, what other characteristics are driving the district to spend more on certain schools?
3. What would you recommend the district do to distribute funding more equitably across its schools?
4. Beyond school funding, how can District X leaders better understand the resources Black/Latinx students and students with high needs receive? How can they better understand the ways the experiences of these students

compare with the experiences of their peers?

Guiding questions as scaffolded support

The guiding questions below are designed to provide scaffolded support for developing your approach. They should help shape your methodology, thought process, and decisions when analyzing the data to arrive at answers to the superintendent's key questions.

Questions one, two, and three

- a) Break down District X's definition of equity into its component parts. What set of conditions must be true about school funding in District X for it to be equitable? How might you measure these conditions?
- b) Look through the data in the spreadsheet you received. What data can you use to test whether these conditions for equitable funding exist in District X today?
- c) Organize a set of summary metrics and/or data visualizations that you think best tests whether District X funds its schools equitably. Take time to track your insights along the way.
- d) Repeat this process to explore what other characteristics drive district spending on schools in District X.
- e) Create a clear summary of your findings and recommendations. Remember to explicitly address the superintendent's key questions.

Question four

- a) To know that District X is making progress towards more equitable school experiences:
 - What must be true about the resources provided to Black and Latinx students and students with high needs?
 - What must be true about these students' experiences in school?
- b) What data could district leaders use to test progress towards the experiences you described? What questions should they consider?
- c) Do not conduct any analysis for this question. Instead, describe a few of the most important questions and analyses you would recommend the district pursue.

Operational definitions

All data shown reflects the 2018–2019 school year unless otherwise noted.

- Row ID: Ignore this column. It's our internal ID to match data back to original dataset.
- School expenses on a \$pp: The amount of money a school spends per student. This includes *all* resources a school utilizes, for example, teacher/staff compensation.
- Projected PreK-12 enrollment: The school's projected enrollment in Spring 2017 when the district was trying to plan for the upcoming year.
- Actual K-12 enrollment: The actual enrollment of the school in September 2018 at the start of the school year
- Title I school: Program to provide supplemental funds to school districts to assist schools with large concentrations of low-income students to help meet their educational goals.
- Choice school: School choice allows public education funds to follow students to the schools or services that best fit their needs—whether that's to a public school, private school, charter school, home school, or any other learning environment families choose.
- Turnaround school: To put it briefly, turnaround schools are those that are undergoing an institutional makeover. From staff to infrastructure to instructional style, turnaround schools are striving to meet the Adequate Yearly Progress (AYP) benchmarks that they consistently and currently fall short of.
- School grade: A ranking used by school districts to evaluate the performance of a school. Most K-12 school districts in the United States use a *school grade* system that combines test scores of students with school satisfaction survey measures.
- Region: An arbitrary way that District X divides schools. Region is not reflective of a specific neighborhood, area, or community in District X. There is no rhyme or reason that a school is in a specific region.

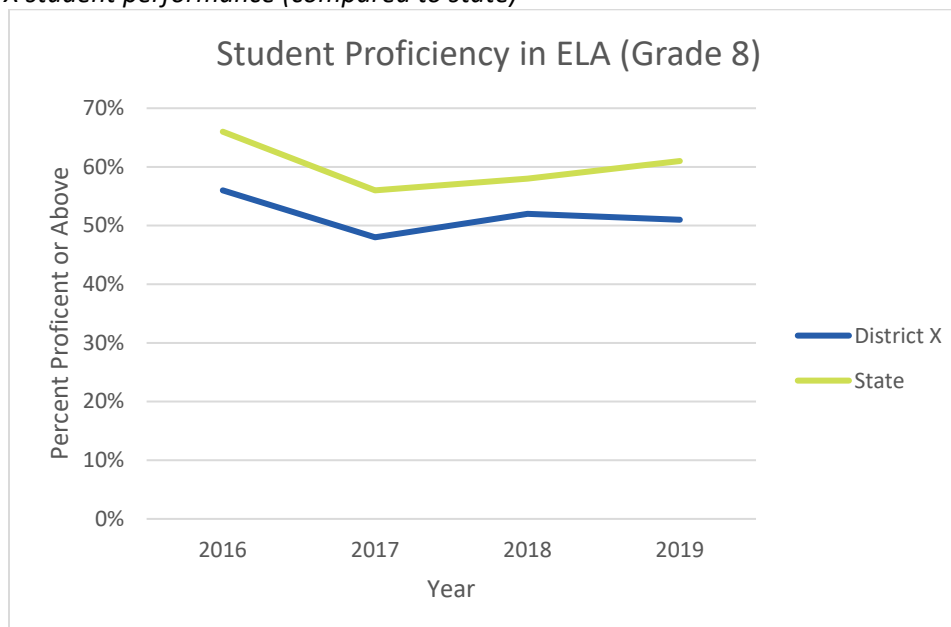
- ELA: An abbreviation for English Language Arts. It's the school subject area that focuses on reading, writing, speaking, and listening skills in English.
- ELL: An abbreviation for English Language Learners. Students whose first language is not English and who are learning English in school.
- FRL: An abbreviation for public school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch, typically students from low-income families.
- SWD: An abbreviation for students with disabilities.

Additional District X artifacts

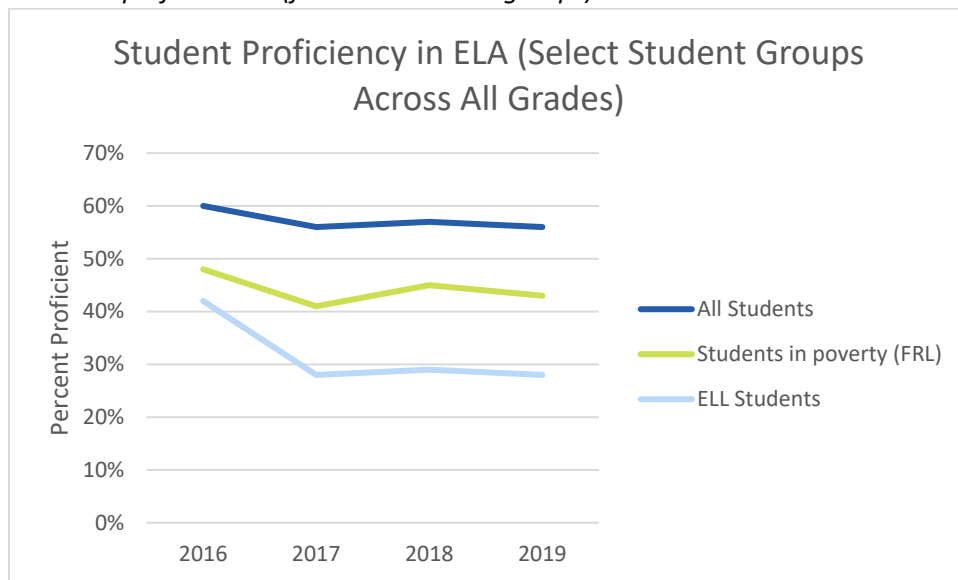
Summary of student demographics

Student demographics	District X	State
Eligible for free or reduced-price lunch (FRL)	58.9%	30.1%
English language learners (ELL)	3.2%	5.6%
Students with disabilities (SWD)	13.8%	11.3%
Student race/ethnicity	District X	State
Black	44.2%	16.6%
White	40.0%	63.9%
Latinx	6.7%	10.4%
Multiracial	4.2%	3.9%
Asian/Pacific Islander	3.9%	4.2%
Native American	0.1%	0.2%
Other	0.9%	0.8%

District X student performance (compared to state)



District X student performance (for select student groups)



District X student performance (by race/ethnicity)

